

CO-SIGN

a short film

Blue Sheep Films

working draft v1.1

INT. FRANK'S KITCHEN - DAY

A kitchen that hasn't changed since 2004 and is proud of it. Same table. Same clock. On the fridge: a car dealership magnet holding nothing, where a kid's drawings used to go.

RILEY (26) sits at the table with a folder he's holding like a summons. FRANK (58), work shirt on his day off, pours two coffees without asking. One lands in front of Riley, in the mug that has been Riley's mug since he was tall enough to break it.

FRANK

So.

RILEY

So.

FRANK

You said papers.

Riley slides the folder over. Frank puts on his reading glasses – a small event; he hates being seen putting on the reading glasses – and reads the title of the top page.

RESIDENTIAL LEASE APPLICATION – GUARANTOR / CO-SIGNER SECTION.

He doesn't say anything. He reads it the way he reads transmission diagnostics: fully, twice.

FRANK (CONT'D)

They won't take you on your own.

RILEY

Nobody gets taken on their own anymore, Dad. It's not – everyone my age has a co-signer or a couch.

FRANK

I didn't have either.

RILEY

I know. Rent was also four hundred dollars.

Frank lets that go. First mercy of the afternoon.

MAIN TITLE: CO-SIGN

INT. FRANK'S KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

The form, flat between them. Frank clicks a pen that says PARKWAY AUTOMOTIVE on it.

FRANK
(reading)
"Full legal name of co-signer."

He prints it. Careful block letters, the handwriting of a man who fills out work orders.

FRANK (CONT'D)
"Relationship to applicant."

His pen stops over the little box. A second. Two seconds. The clock does one loud tick, involved now.

RILEY
It's "father," Dad. It's not a
trick question.

FRANK
I know what it is.

He writes FATHER. It takes slightly too long, like the word weighs more than its letters.

INT. FRANK'S KITCHEN - LATER

Deeper into the form. The coffee's gone lukewarm, the way it does around paperwork.

FRANK
(reading)
"Applicant's annual income."

Silence.

RILEY
Just — give me the pen, I'll do
that box.

FRANK
The box is on my side of the page.

RILEY
Thirty-one five.

Frank's pen doesn't move.

FRANK
With the second job?

RILEY
That is with the second job.

Frank writes the number down. Says nothing. The nothing is enormous and Riley stares into his mug where it can't see him.

FRANK (CONT'D)
(reading, gentler now,
though he'd deny it)
"Applicant's years at current
address."

RILEY
One.

FRANK
Before that?

RILEY
Eleven months. Then the place on
Concord for eight. Then Mick's
basement, but that wasn't – that
was informal.

Frank looks up. Not at Riley. At the kitchen – the one he's been in for thirty-one years, that cost him less than Riley's phone bill probably, and both of them know it, and neither of them says it, because what would be the point.

FRANK
Four addresses in three years.

RILEY
Welcome to it.

INT. FRANK'S KITCHEN - LATER

The last page. CO-SIGNER ACKNOWLEDGEMENT, a paragraph of liability in small print. Frank actually reads it. Of course he actually reads it.

RILEY
It just says if I miss rent, they
come after you.

FRANK
I know what it says.

RILEY
I won't miss rent.

FRANK
I know you won't.

He still doesn't sign. The pen sits on the table between them like a dare. Riley finally cracks:

RILEY
Look — if it's the money, if it's
the risk, I get it. I'll figure
out something else. Mick's got a—

FRANK
It's not the money.

RILEY
Then what?

Frank turns his mug a quarter turn. The tell. Riley's known that tell his whole life; it means the next sentence costs something.

FRANK
When I was your age I asked my
father to co-sign a loan. Four
hundred dollars. For the tools.
You can't work without your own
tools.

(beat)
He said no. Said it'd build
character.

RILEY
What'd you do?

FRANK
Slept in the van behind the
Canadian Tire for five weeks and
bought them one at a time.
(beat)
Great character back there behind
the Canadian Tire. Highly
recommend it.

He picks up the pen. Signs. His full signature — the fancy one, the loan-documents one, not the delivery-slip scrawl.

FRANK (CONT'D)
Nobody signed for me. That's not a
tradition. That's just a thing
that happened to me.

He caps the pen and slides the folder back across the table.

RILEY
(thick, hiding it badly)
I'll never miss a payment.

FRANK
Miss one. See what happens.

It's a threat and a promise and an I-love-you, in the dialect they both actually speak.

INT. FRANK'S KITCHEN - LATER

The goodbye shuffle at the door. Riley has the folder. Then Frank takes it back –

FRANK
Hang on.

– and feeds the co-signer page into the ancient printer-copier in the hall. It groans. Produces a warm copy.

Frank takes his copy to the fridge and pins it up with the dealership magnet. Dead centre. Where the drawings went.

Riley watches him do it. Neither of them comments, because commenting would wreck it, and they are professionals.

FRANK (CONT'D)
So I don't forget what I'm on the hook for.

RILEY
Sure, Dad.

That is not what it's for, and everyone in the kitchen and the audience knows it.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END